Portable generator maintenance schedule

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For gas portable generators, the 3 to 10 kW job-site and inverter kind. The first oil change comes fast on a new one, and older carbureted models want oil about twice as often as newer inverter models.

Typical intervals from manufacturer manuals and published service schedules. Your machine's manual comes first.

Break-in (new generators)

TASK	HOW OFTEN	NOTES	✓
First oil change	5 to 30 hours	Some makers say the first month	

Every use or 8 hours

TASK	HOW OFTEN	NOTES	✓
Check oil level	Every use or 8 hours		
Check the air filter	Every use		
Clean around the air intake and muffler	Daily		
Test the GFCI outlets	Every use	Where the generator has them	
Long outages: shut down to cool, refuel and check	Every 8 hours		

By hours

TASK	HOW OFTEN	NOTES	✓
Oil change	Every 50 to 100 hours or each season	Sooner under heavy load or in heat	
Clean the air filter	About every 50 hours	Sooner in dust	
Spark plug: clean and gap	About every 100 hours		
Clean the spark arrester screen	Every 100 to 300 hours		
Replace the air filter element	Every 200 to 300 hours or yearly		
Replace the spark plug	Yearly or about 300 hours		
Valve clearance	Every 100 to 1,000 hours	Varies a lot by model; usually a shop job	

Yearly and longer

TASK	HOW OFTEN	NOTES	✓
Oil, plug and filters, even if hours are low	Yearly	A generator that barely runs still needs these	
Check the fuel line	Every 2 years		
Replace the fuel line	About every 3 years		

Service log: portable generator

Machine / unit: _____ Make & model: _____

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DATE	HOURS	WORK DONE	PARTS USED	INITIALS

Free printable from fleetoptima.org/maintenance-schedules